it could have been, no one could have been sure of how successful it would be until D-day arrived. On the very first day of the Yatra, it was clear to everyone that it was going to achieve more than just unite India. People from all walks of life joined the Yatra as if they were just waiting for something like this to happen. The overwhelming participation of people in the Yatra also reflected the extent of their disapproval of the BJP government. Unlike Prime Minister Modi, Rahul Gandhi listened to what they had to say, and became one of them. The political utility to the Congress party cannot be denied, as it was something every single colleague was discussing. The enthusiasm was palpable, because after years of lethargy and losses, we all felt the Yatra could rejuvenate the party.

The Personal

By the time I was in a position to apply to join the Bharat Jodo Yatra, I had heard so much about it that I had no reason to think twice about being part of it. I felt that it was my duty to express solidarity and be part of this noble quest. I did have concerns about whether I had the physical endurance to actually do it—walking 4,000 kilometres is no joke! However, the response that the Yatra received on its very first day was so overwhelming that my doubts melted away.

Strangely, walking in shoes made me very uncomfortable. Sachin Rao, a party colleague, advised that I would feel better if I walked barefoot. However, I was too sceptical to pay heed at that time. But as the Yatra progressed, I faced two major problems. First, I began to develop blisters on my feet. Secondly, I felt completely drained by the evenings. So with considerable hesitation and even more trepidation, I decided to walk barefoot during the afternoon stretch of the Yatra at Kollam. I walked barefoot from Chathannoor to Kollam, and the results were amazing. I felt that my energy levels had increased and I was able to walk faster. The blisters on my feet began to disappear. Over the next few weeks, I developed such strength that I could walk in any terrain and climate. So